

Logic Programming

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CS @ UTCN

Lecture #0
Administrative Information
Computer Science

Administrative information

- English track
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 - Richard Ardelean
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 - Room M03 (Teams & Moodle)
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Structure of the course

- **Labs (f2f, Baritiu, ex BT building, 5th floor)**
 - same content, every group a different faculty member, or a (graduate) PhD student or master student
 - HANDS ON Problem solving (again: for ANY solution WHY? WHAT IF?)
 - Prolog
- **Seminars (f2f, Baritiu)**
 - Problem solving – analysis and design, evaluation, comparisons
 - Almost always asked: WHY? WHAT IF? With INTERPRETATION (answer **WITHOUT** running the code).
- **Lectures (f2f, Baritiu)**
 - Slides + code + analysis + discussions
 - Open course with Q&A sessions
 - Stop us and ask questions whenever you have
 - If you have a question, most probably other students have the same question! Ask it!
- **Slides + code + analysis + discussions**
 - <https://moodle.cs.utcluj.ro/course/view.php?id=844>
 - <https://github.com/ArdeleanRichard/utcn-pl/>

Lab sessions info

	Enrollment key (moodle)	TA
30231	2026_Group@30231	<i>Mihai Mircea Mera</i>
30232	2026_Group@30232	<i>Richard Ardelean</i>
30233	2026_Group@30233	<i>Vasile Suciu</i>
30234	2026_Group@30234	<i>Alex Lapusan</i>
30235	2026_Group@30235	<i>Remus Petrache</i>
30236_1	2026_Group@30236_1	<i>Alex Lapusan</i>
30236_2	2026_Group@30236_2	<i>Raluca Portase</i>
30237_1	2026_Group@30237_1	<i>Raluca Portase</i>
30237_2	2026_Group@30237_2	<i>Richard Ardelean</i>
30238	2026_Group@30238	<i>Alin Anghelus</i>
30431	2026_Group@30431	<i>Istvan Czarar</i>
30432	2026_Group@30432	<i>Vlad Negru</i>
30433	2026_Group@30433	<i>Remus Petrache</i>
30434_1	2026_Group@30434_1	<i>Vlad Negru</i>
30434_2	2026_Group@30434_2	<i>Mihai Feier</i>
30435	2026_Group@30435	<i>Raluca Portase</i>
Re	2026_Group@RE	-

References

- **No bible this time**
- **Instead, several references**
 - Moodle course page
 - <https://github.com/ArdeleanRichard/utc-n-pl/tree/main/resources/Books>

Go check the CS library (Baritiu 26-28, Room M04)



Evaluation (FG formula)

- **Laboratory works / Hands on evaluation (30% of FG)**
 - Attend laboratory sessions with *your* group
 - 12 lab works, must work during the lab sessions, must upload work on moodle
 - Activity during the semester will be part of your lab grade!
 - Final evaluation, at the end of the semester (written + oral)
 - need a lab grade of 5 or more to be allowed to take the final exam
 - **CANNOT retake** the lab exam
- **Midterm (20% of FG)**
 - In the 5th school week, during the course
 - **CANNOT retake** the midterm
- **FE (50% of FG)**
 - 1h examination (**Moodle**): problem solving only (NO THEORY)
 - This is for FG up to 8
 - Quiz-like questions, a mock quiz will be made available around week 7-8
 - Oral examination just for FG > 8
 - Based on prior enrollment
 - Permission granted based on lab and FE performance (TBD)

Final Grade formula

- **$FG = 30\%LG + 20\%MG + 50\%FEG + \text{Bonus}$**
 - **$FEG = 70\%MEG + 30\%OEG$**
- **Conditions to pass:**
 - **Preconditions:**
 - $LG \geq 5$
 - $MEG \geq 5$
 - $FG \geq 4.5$ (applicable only AFTER preconditions met)
- **BONUS** (awarded based on Seminar & Lectures Activity)
 - Apply a +[0 to 1] point

FG=Final Grade
MG=Midterm Grade
LG=Lab Grade
FEG=Final Exam Grade

MEG – Moodle Exam Grade
OEG – Oral Exam Grade

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Lecture #1

Introduction to Logic Programming

Agenda

- **What this course is/is NOT about**
- **Logic in Programming**
- **Main LP elements**
- **LP program**
 - Syntax
 - Semantic
 - Execution tree

What this course is about?

- **Course on Logic Programming**
 - Define the LP **syntax** and **semantics**
 - Understand the **execution mechanism**
 - Learn the main **LP paradigms**
 - ***Language as executable specifications***
 - Practice in a **LP language** (Prolog and “dialects”)
- **General CS practice**
 - Basic **problem solving**
 - ***Revise Data Structures and Algorithms*** from the LP perspective

In a nutshell...

- Programming so far:
 - Imperative (procedural languages)
 - assumes the presence of an assignment ($:=$) operator
 - specific control structures used
 - presence of side effects
- Declarative languages (symbolic languages)
 - Functional and *logic* languages
 - Assignment operation NOT present
 - Control removed from programmer (*mostly*; in a pure LP style, all of it)
 - No side effects (*in pure LP*; specific mechanisms implementing side effects exist)

In a nutshell...

- Program = Algorithm + **Data Structure**
 - Wirth (book title)
- Algorithm = ***Logic*** + **Control**
 - Kowalsky's statement

LP philosophy

- Program:
 - In conventional programming languages - describing the algorithm using the language's syntax
 - In LP - describing formal relationships occurring among objects (here objects NOT in the OO meaning)
 - Focus on the descriptive perspective rather than the prescriptive one
 - A LP program = collection of known facts and relationships between components, rather than a sequence of steps to be taken
 - Computation is carried out by the specification (with logic embedded in the declarative semantic + new facts inferred) and just partially by explicit control information supplied by the program
- LP main characteristics:
 - **Logic variables**
 - **Shared structures**
 - **Unification** mechanism (matching)
 - Search for **alternative solutions** (when writing *nondeterministic* solutions)

LP syntax

- We'll use PROLOG to generically denote Logic Languages
 - PROLOG = PROgramming LOGic
 - For a brief history check references and [Prolog Heritage](#)
- NO keywords (just a very few; we'll learn them on the fly)
- NO statements
- The program is just what you write
- **Case sensitive** language
 - Variables – first letter UPPER case (*Variable*, *VARIABLE*, *VaRiAbLe* are all variables; *_variable* is constant)
 - Constants – first letter LOWER case (*constant*, *cONSTANT*, *cOnStAnT* are all constants; *_Constant* is variable)
- Matching basic operation (evaluation rare, just by **explicit request**)
 - Example: **A=a**
 - means A unifies (matches) with a and NOT that A takes the value of a
 - Unification = the attempt to make the two sides the same
 - Successful matching (TRUE) – they are the SAME from now on
 - Unsuccessful matching (FALSE or fail in Prolog jargon) – backtracking mechanism installed (see later)

LP syntax

- Program = collection of predicates
- Predicate = a description (in Prolog syntax) of theorems
 - a collection of clauses
 - name of a predicate = a constant (starts with lower case)
- The general form of a clause is represented by:

$p(X) :- q_1(Y), q_2(X, Y), \dots, q_n(X, Z) .$

(to be read as p of X if ... q1 of Y and ...)

$p, q_i, i=1, \dots, n$ represent names of predicates (first letter lower case)

X, Y, Z arguments (variables = start with upper case)

X = parameter

Y, Z = local variables (hidden variables; explained later)

$p(X)$ = head of the clause

$q_i, i=1 \dots n$ = body of the clause (sub-query)

$:-$ = if

$,$ = and (conjunction)

$.$ = full stop (end of clause). Dot is mandatory.

Prolog PREDICATES (clauses)

- The general form of a **clause** is represented by:

$$p(X) :- q_1(Y), q_2(X,Y), \dots, q_n(X,Z).$$

head :- body.

Left hand side (lhs) <IF> right hand side (rhs).

- Clause
 - a **theorem** = a representation in Prolog syntax of the relationships (body) among the objects (variables) occurring in the clause; it has a standalone meaning
 - Can be viewed as a procedure (function, method) from imperative (procedural, OO) languages
 - The conclusion of the theorem (head, lhs) is true if all the hypotheses of the theorem (rhs) are true
 - p - head
 - $q_i, i=1\dots n$ - body
 - Meaning: the head is true (p ; lhs) **if** the body (rhs) is true ($q_i, i=1\dots n$; rhs)
- Predicate = a set of one or several clauses
- Prolog program = a set of one or several predicates

Prolog PREDICATES (rules, facts, queries)

- The general form of a **clause** is represented by:

$$p(X) :- q_1(Y), q_2(X, Y), \dots, q_n(X, Z).$$

- Particular form of clauses:
 - General form – above (**rule**)
 - Particular forms: **facts** and **queries**

- **Fact**

= a clause without body

= a theorem WITHOUT hypothesis = AXIOM (no need for proof)

$p(a).$ % meaning *p of a is true, without condition.*

- **Query**

= a clause without head

= a theorem WITHOUT conclusion = only hypotheses which need proof

= if true, will be a new axiom

$?- q_2(a, b).$ % meaning *check if q₂ of a and b is true.*

This defines the **declarative semantics** of Prolog = interpretation of the statements

•
•
•
p
p
•
•
•

•

•

•

```
?- father(john, Z).
```

The first LP program

```
man(john) .           %john, lower case start is a man.
.
.
.
parent(john,david) .  % john is david's parent
parent(john,edward) . % john is edward's parent
.                     % could be the other way around
.                     % david is john's parent
.                     % is up to us; depends on how WE define it!

father(X,Y) :-        % X is Y's father IF (by :- sign)
    man(X) ,          % X is man AND (by ,)
    parent(X,Y) .     % X is Y's parent. That's all.

?- father(john, Z).   % whose father is john? Return the result in Z.
```

Execution of the first LP program: Questions to answer

- How is it working?
 - Matching mechanism
 - Match the query against the head of the clause of the predicate with the same name (`father` in our case) = *query/head unification*
- Some questions need to be answered:
 - **Q1: what if query/head unification have several alternatives** (*translates into: predicate has several clauses*)
 - **Q2: what if query/head unification succeeds and we have a body** (*translates into: we have a complete clause we matched with*)
 - **Q3: what if query/head unification fails** (*translates into: we have an unsuccessful matching*)
- The answers define the **procedural semantics** of PROLOG = interpreting the statements as actions to take (call and run) (also named **operational semantics**)

Execution of the first LP program answers to questions

- **Q1:** what if query/head **unification** have several alternatives (translated: predicate with several clauses)
 - **R1:** first clause first = **top-down**
- **Q2:** what if query/head unification succeeds and we have a body (translated: complete clause)
 - **R2:** first subgoal (sub-body) first = **left-right**
- **Q3:** what if query/head unification fails (translated: unsuccessful matching)
 - **R3:** unification fails = **backtracking**
 - Backtracking is a build-in mechanism = it automatically launches in case of failure

LP operational semantics

- Defined by the answers from before:
 - (R1) **Selection** (computation) rule: the top/down approach
 - (R2) **Search** rule: the left/right approach
 - (R3) **Backtracking** by default

Execution of the first LP program

```
[m1] man(john) .  
...
```

```
[p1] parent(john,david) .  
[p2] parent(john,edward) .  
...
```

```
[f1] father(X,Y) :-  
[f11]     man(X) ,  
[f12]     parent(X,Y) .
```

```
[q] ?- father(john,Z) .
```

R1: (1) **q/f1:** father(john,Z)/father(X,Y) => X=john, Z=Y

It results the CONCLUSION could be true in case all conjunction in the body is true as well, the body of the clause becomes the NEW goal (or query) to execute.

So, the NEW goal is an instance of f11,f12, that is:

[f11],[f12] = man(X) , parent(X,Y) .

Where X and Y got instantiated already (X and Y are shared variables; shared as they are THE SAME as in the head of the rule)

R2 tells us f11 gets executed before f12; moreover, f12 is executed **iff** f11 is TRUE.

Execution of the first LP program – contd.

R1: top-down

R2: left-right

R3: backtrack upon failure

?- man(X), parent(X, Y) . % **f11, f12**

a2 tells us to *SOLVE f11 and PUT on hold f12*

(what happens: the entire query is put on the exe. stack, f12 on bottom, f11 on top; the exec. pops the top of the stack)

f11: ?- man(X) . is the new query to execute => Q1 => **a1** =>

(2) f11/m1: man(X) /man(john) => X=john succeeds.

Is a fact => unconditionally true => f11 IS TRUE.

(*) In a query/rule match, HOW DO WE CONTINUE? We must check 3 conditions (for a **final** successful unification) in the specific order:

- **C1: current goal succeeds?**
- **C2: is a fact?**
- **C3: is the execution stack empty?**

Continuation depends on how the conditions are (not) met.

(remember: the execution stack contains the goals to execute)

Execution mechanism – conditions to check

- C1: current goal succeeds? *If yes, go C2,
else, backtrack.*
- C2: is it a fact? *If yes, go C3,
else, push the entire body on the
execution stack, and pop stack's top.*
- C3: is the stack empty? *If yes, over (the whole execution ends
successfully),
else pop the top of the execution stack
and continue execution (from C1)*
- Backtrack means WHAT?
 - UNDO the latest unification (that is, REMOVE latest matching) and
 - for the given goal, try a different alternative (next one, if any)
 - If again fail (or no other alternative), the backtracking mechanism propagates in REVERSE order of the execution.

Execution of the first LP program – contd.

?- man (X) , parent (X, Y) . % **f11, f12**

Solved f11; so?

- C1: current goal succeeds?

YES => unification succeeds => successful node in the execution tree

- C2: is a fact?

YES => node is a leaf in the tree

- C3: is the stack empty?

NO => pop the top and it becomes the right sibling of the latest node

In our case, pop -> **[f12]** ?- parent (X, Y) . is the new query to execute => Q1 => A1 =>

(3) f12/p1: parent (X, Y) / parent (john, david) .

BUT, from the previous query we had => X=john, and X is shared (among the body and head), thus here we actually have:

john=john (T) and Y=david (T)

So, successful matching.

Execution of the first LP program – contd.

f12 = parent (X, Y) .

Solved f12; so?

- C1: current goal succeeds? YES => unification succeeds => successful node in the execution tree
- C2: is a fact? YES => node is a leaf in the tree
- C3: is the stack empty? YES => the whole execution ends successfully

So, successful matching. Where is the answer?

Following the deduction tree, we have the entire unification chain (next slides)

Computer Science

Here goes the deduction tree

```
[m1] man(john) .
```

```
...
```

```
[p1] parent(john,david) .
```

```
[p2] parent(john,edward) .
```

```
...
```

```
[f1] father(X,Y) :-
```

```
[f11]     man(X) ,
```

```
[f12]     parent(X,Y) .
```

```
[q] ?-father(john,Z) .
```

Here goes the deduction tree

```
[m1] man(john) .
```

...

```
[p1] parent(john,david) .
```

```
[p2] parent(john,edward) .
```

...

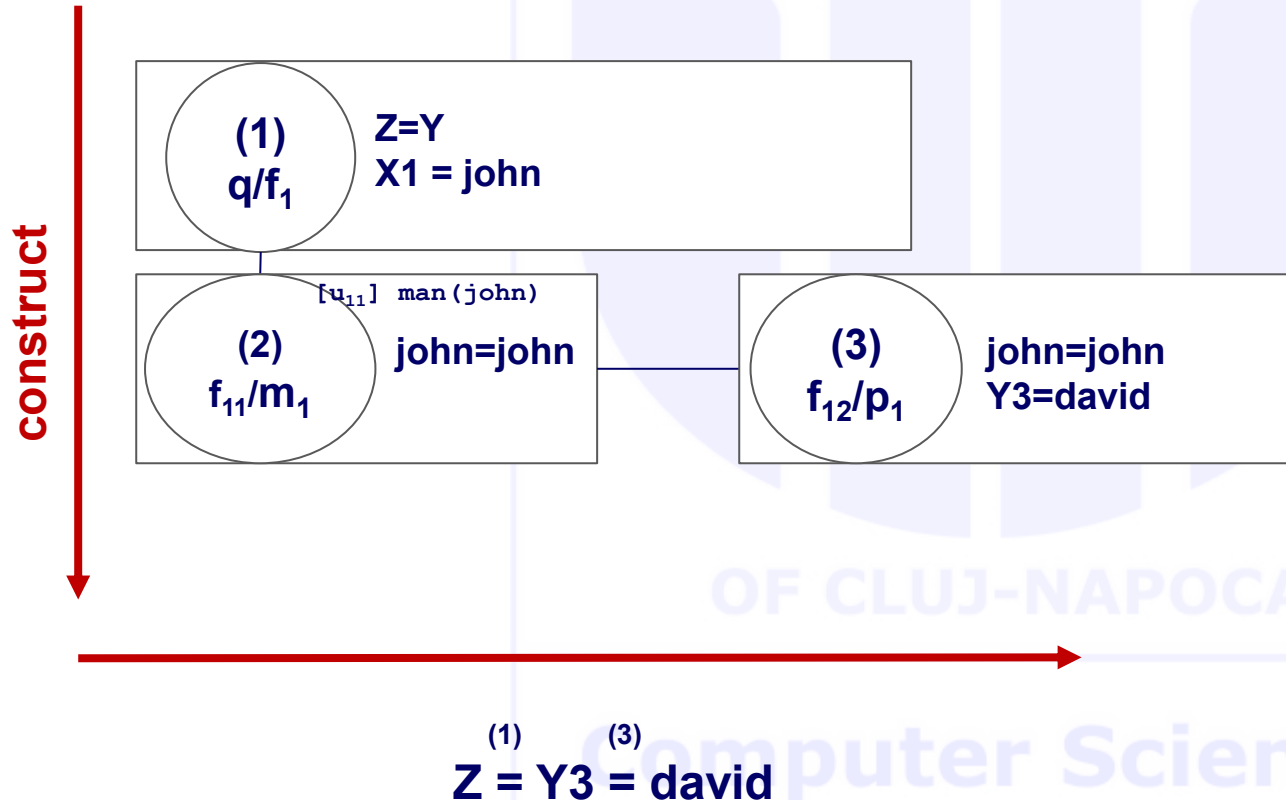
```
[f1] father(X,Y) :-
```

```
[f11]     man(X) ,
```

```
[f12]     parent(X,Y) .
```

```
[q] ?- father(john,Z) .
```

true, Z=david



Deduction Tree

- The final **successful** shape of an execution tree forms the **deduction** tree
 - Execution tree contains all nodes – even erased ones
- It stores the query/head matchings along with the unifications (formal vs actual arguments) made during the execution
- **Nondeterministic** behavior of Prolog = ability to find alternative solutions (if any) of the problem at hand
 - It is performed via launching the **backtracking** mechanism (built-in)
 - It refers to **repeating** the query; repeating the query is NOT asking the SAME query (if so, the SAME answer is provided)
 - repeating the query is: for the SAME query AND in the context of the ALREADY built deduction tree, what OTHER possible answers are there?
 - Syntactically, it is specified by “;” (at command prompt), and it says: in the tree you already have, take the nodes in reverse order and try to find an alternative matching
 - So, the LAST built node attempts to backtrack and only after it has no other choice it asks its predecessor node to backtrack.

Backtracking

- Evolution backwards in a tree already built
- The last built, the first to backtrack
- We had: (1)

(1) q/f1

(2) f12/m1

(3) f12/p1 backtrack on this =>

ERASE THE NODE and try **(3') f12/p2** `parent(X,Y) / parent(john,edward) .`

BUT, from the previous query (2) we had => `X=john`, and `X` is shared (among the body and head), thus here we actually have:

`john=john (T)` and `Y=edward (T)`

So, successful matching.

Following the new deduction tree we have the whole unification chain:

Here goes the deduction tree

```
[m1] man(john) .
```

...

```
[p1] parent(john,david) .
```

```
[p2] parent(john,edward) .
```

...

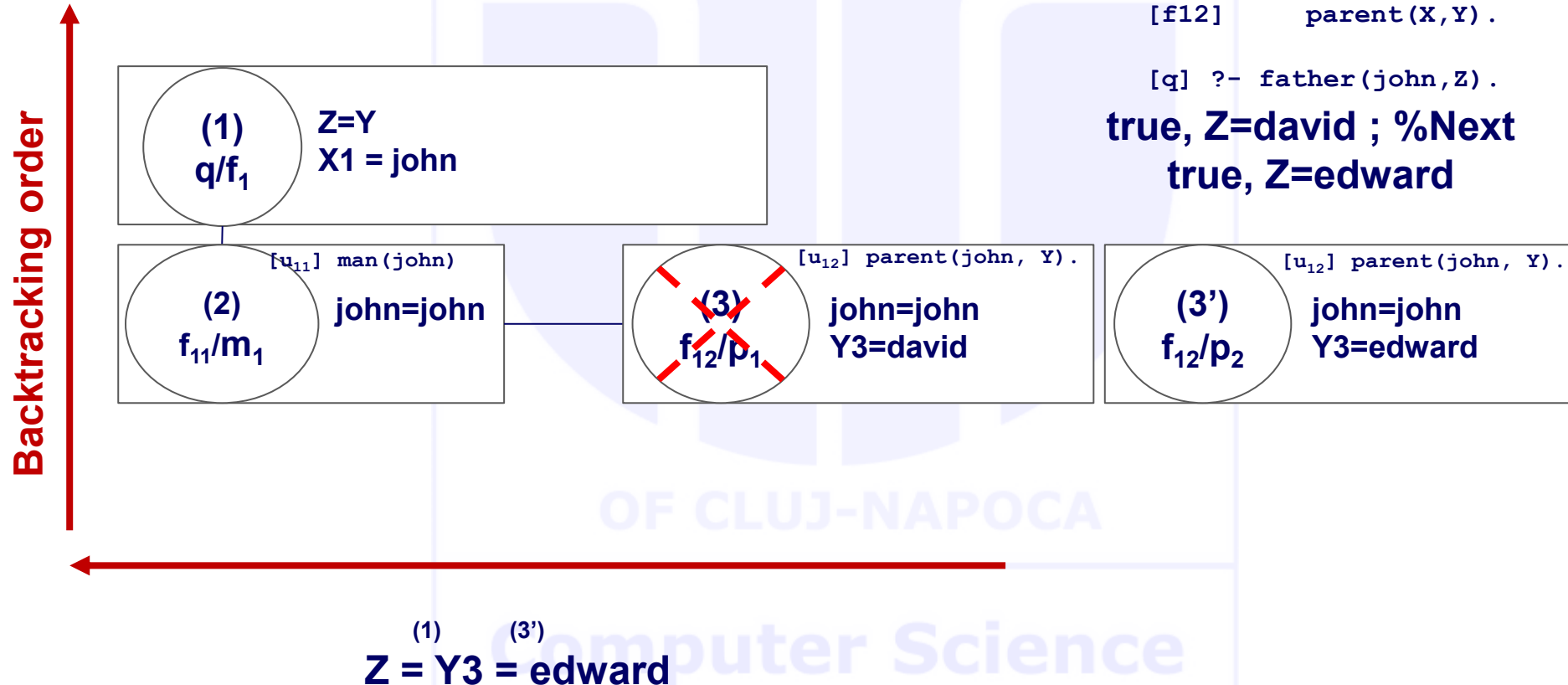
```
[f1] father(X,Y) :-
```

```
[f11]     man(X) ,
```

```
[f12]     parent(X,Y) .
```

```
[q] ?- father(john,Z) .
```

```
true, Z=david ; %Next
true, Z=edward
```



Backtracking until final failure

- If we need ANOTHER answer, the evolution backwards in the new shape of the tree (1, 2 and 3')
- The last built, the first to backtrack
- We had:

(1) q/f1

(2) f12/m1

(3') f12/p2 backtrack on this => ERASE THE NODE and try **(3'') f12/p3**

Assume p3 has as first argument something different from j_{ohn}

(3'') fails to build, (3'') is erased and the backtracking propagates on to 2:

(2') f12/m2 fails (as m2 has something different from j_{ohn} , and 2 constants unify iff they represent the same constant)

(2') fails to build, (2') is erased and the backtracking propagates on to 1:

(1') q/? No other clause exists => FINAL FAILURE

Meaning: NO other solution exists

Action: the whole tree is removed from memory (*go to the prev page to see*)

Execution mechanism – review

- Rule 1: **Search** rule:
the left to right evaluation of goals in conjunction
- Rule 2: **Selection** (computation) rule:
the top-down selection of clauses from the program
- Rule 3: **Backtracking** by default:
(see later lectures mechanisms for avoiding it when not necessary)

OF CLUJ-NAPOCA

Computer Science

First conclusions

- a Prolog **program** is a set of **theorems** (complete clauses) and axioms (facts)
- Executing a Prolog program means **proving a new theorem** (the query/goal) from the existing ones (program)
- The execution relies on **solving** a set of **systems of linear equations**
- The number of systems = number of nodes in the deduction tree
- Each system has a number of equations equal to the number of arguments of the goal executed in the corresponding node

List representation and decomposing lists

Lists: $[1,2,3]$ – comma separated elements

- NO type required (heterogeneous lists by default)
- $[a,b,c]$ how is it different from $[A,B,C]$?
- $[]$ empty list
- $[H|T]$ Head/Tail decomposition pattern with meaning:
 - H = the first element of the list
 - T = the rest of the list (= the list with the first element removed)
- $[H|T] = [a,b,c]$ unification/matching
 - Before, H, T free variables
 - Now, bound to specific constants: $H=a, T=[b,c]$
- $[H|T] = [a]$
 - $H=a, T=[]$
- $[H|T] = []$
 - Fails, as H CANNOT unify the first element of the list (as there is NO element at all)
- $[H1,H2|T] = [H1|[H2|T]]$ just rewriting rule
- In **LP basic operator is matching**
(as opposed to FP where evaluator is the basic operation)

Example 2 – concatenating lists

```
append(L1, L2, R) :-  
    L1 = [],                % L1 empty  
    R = L2.                % R gets L2  
  
append(L1, L2, R) :-  
    L1 = [H1 | T],          % decomposition pattern; dec L1 into head and tail  
    append(T, L2, Rp),      % recurse on tail to get the partial result  
    H = H1,  
    R = [H | Rp].           % recomposition pattern; rec R from head and tail
```

Order of clauses?

impact on correctness? Why?

impact on efficiency? How?

Example 2 contd

```
append(L1, L2, R) :-  
    L1 = [],                % L1 empty  
    R = L2.                % R gets L2  
  
append(L1, L2, R) :-  
    L1 = [H1 | T],          % decomposition pattern; dec L1 into head and tail  
    append(T, L2, Rp),      % recurse on tail to get the partial result  
    H = H1,  
    R = [H | Rp].           % recomposition pattern; rec R from head and tail
```

Here we have explicit unifications.

By replacing them with **default** unifications, we get:

```
append([], L, L).  
append([H | T], L, [H | R]) :-  
    append(T, L, R).
```

Example 2 execution

```
[a1] append([],L,L).  
[a2] append([H|T],L,[H|R]):-  
[a21]         append(T,L,R).  
[q]  ?- append([1,2],[3,4],Result).
```

Here goes equations and tree.

(1) **q/a1** $[1,2]=[]$ fails, default backtracking

Example 2 execution

```
[a1] append([],L,L).  
[a2] append([H|T],L,[H|R]):-  
[a21]         append(T,L,R).  
[q]  ?- append([1,2],[3,4],Result).
```

Here goes equations and tree.

```
(1)  q/a1  [1,2]=[]  fails, default backtracking  
(1') q/a2  [H1|T1]=[1,2] => H1=1, T1=[2]  
      L1=[3,4]  
      Result=[H1|R1] => Result=[1|R1]  
a21: append(T1,L1,R1)
```

Example 2 execution

```
[a1] append([],L,L) .
[a2] append([H|T],L,[H|R]) :-
[a21]         append(T,L,R) .
[q]  ?- append([1,2],[3,4],Result) .
```

Here goes equations and tree.

```
(1)  q/a1  [1,2]=[ ]  fails, default backtracking
(1') q/a2  [H1|T1]=[1,2] => H1=1, T1=[2]
      L1=[3,4]
      Result=[H1|R1] => Result=[1|R1]
a21: append(T1,L1,R1) (why?) and translates into append([2],[3,4],R1)
(2)  a21/a1 fails
(2') a21/a2 [H2|T2]=[2] => H2=2, T2=[ ]
      L2=[3,4]
      R1=[H2|R2] => R1=[2|R2]
a21: append(T2,L2,R2)
```

Example 2 execution

```
[a1] append([],L,L) .
[a2] append([H|T],L,[H|R]) :-
[a21]         append(T,L,R) .
[q]  ?- append([1,2],[3,4],Result) .
```

Here goes equations and tree.

```
(1)  q/a1  [1,2]=[ ] fails, default backtracking
(1')  q/a2  [H1|T1]=[1,2] => H1=1, T1=[2]
        L1=[3,4]
        Result=[H1|R1] => Result=[1|R1]
a21: append(T1,L1,R1) (why?) and translates into append([2],[3,4],R1)
(2)  a21/a1 fails
(2')  a21/a2 [H2|T2]=[2] => H2=2, T2=[ ]
        L2=[3,4]
        R1=[H2|R2] => R1=[2|R2]
a21: append(T2,L2,R2) translates into append([],[3,4],R2)
(3)  a21/a1 [ ]=[ ] L3=[3,4] R2=L3
        Result=[1|R1]=[1|[2|R2]]=[1,2|R2]=[1,2|L3]=[1,2|[3,4]]=[1,2,3,4]
```